

IRREPRESSIBLE, IMPACTFUL, INSPIRATIONAL

We are all richer for having **experienced Vinesh Phogat** as long as we did. There weren't many like her, and there won't be many like her.

Jonathan Selvaraj

jonathan.selvaraj@thehindu.co.in

On August 9, Vinesh Phogat announced her retirement from the sport of wrestling in a post on X. After the previous day's incidents, it was a message that many had been expecting.

Vinesh experienced the highest of highs at the Paris Olympics. She defeated an unbeaten Olympic champion wrestler who was considered not just the favourite in her weight division but across every weight division at the quadrennial event. She became the first Indian woman wrestler to reach an Olympic final. However, Vinesh also faced the lowest of lows at the Olympics. No one had ever reached an Olympic final only to be denied the chance to compete because they had failed to make weight on the day of the competition.

Vinesh had taken her case to the Court of Arbitration for Sport, seeking at least to be awarded a silver medal by virtue of reaching the final. If she had succeeded, she would have set a precedent, but, much to the

disappointment of the nation, her appeal was turned down by the sole arbitrator, Annabelle Bennett.

The medal ceremony may be over, and the Olympics might be done, but Vinesh has still not admitted defeat.

It had to be Vinesh Phogat.

No one apart from her could whiplash from the extreme jubilation to the pits of despair overnight in a manner that would captivate the entire country. And who else but her could initiate a battle that could change the way sports are governed?

Vinesh has always been a fighter. Tragedy has followed her, yet somehow, against the odds, she has emerged victorious.

When she was nine, her father was shot dead by someone in her village, believed to be a mentally